Personal Statement Guide

Show your story • Highlight your impact • Build your future

A strong personal statement is not only a list of what you have done. It shows who you are, what you have learned, and where you are going. Selection committees often read many statements, so the ones that stand out are specific, honest, and clearly connected to the opportunity.

This guide breaks a five-paragraph statement into four parts. For each part you will find what to include, the key question to answer, questions to ask yourself while you plan, and a short example. If the scholarship provider gives its own instructions, word limit, or questions, follow those first.

Part	Paragraph	Purpose
1. The Hook & Core Purpose	1	Draw the reader in and state your field and long-term goal.
2. Academic Background & Skills	2–3	Show your preparation and how you handled challenges.
3. Leadership & Community Impact	4	Prove that you use your skills to help others.
4. Future Vision & Program Fit	5	Explain your plans and why this opportunity is the right step.

1. The Hook & Core Purpose

Paragraph 1

Your first paragraph decides whether the reader wants to keep going. It should show a real moment or passion, then make clear what you want to study and why.

What to include

- **Opening hook:** Start with a short, specific story, a turning point, or the passion behind your goals. Use a scene only you could write. Avoid cliché quotes and avoid opening with “My name is…”, because the reader already has your name.
- **Thesis statement:** Within the first paragraph, say plainly which field you want to study and what you hope to achieve in the long term. Everything that follows should support this sentence.
- **Link the two:** Show how the moment or passion you described led you to this field.

Key question to answer: What specific vision or problem drives your academic pursuit?

Ask yourself

What made you choose this path?
What do you hope to achieve?

Example (illustrative)

Weaker: “I have always been passionate about technology.”
Stronger: “When the only printer in our community centre broke, I watched students walk two hours to submit forms. That day I decided to learn how to build digital tools that remove barriers like that.”

2. Academic Background & Skills

Paragraphs 2–3

These paragraphs give evidence that you can succeed in the programme. Show what you have actually done, not only the grades you received.

What to include

- **Academic milestones:** Describe relevant coursework, research projects, or self-directed learning connected to your chosen field. Name specific subjects, projects, or skills, and say what you learned from them.
- **Overcoming challenges:** Briefly explain how you handled academic or financial difficulties. Focus on what you did, which shows resilience and resourcefulness. Keep the tone factual rather than asking for sympathy.
- **Connect to the programme:** Show how your background has prepared you for the subject you want to study.

Key question to answer: What concrete evidence proves you have the intellectual capacity to succeed in this programme?

Ask yourself

What have you learned?
What challenges have you overcome?
What makes you ready?

Example (illustrative)

“Without a computer at home, I practised programming on paper and tested my code during limited lab hours. This taught me to plan carefully before I typed a single line.”

3. Leadership & Community Impact

Paragraph 4

Scholarship providers want to invest in people who will use their education to benefit others. This paragraph gives proof that you already do.

What to include

- **Real-world initiative:** Describe a leadership role, volunteer effort, or community initiative that you started or contributed to in a significant way. Explain what your own role was.
- **Measurable results:** Where you can, use numbers to show your impact, for example “trained 15 students” or “organised workshops for over 50 community members”. Only use figures that are true and that you can explain if asked.
- **Skills in action:** Show what the experience taught you and how it shaped your goals.

Key question to answer: How do you use your skills to serve others and create tangible change?

Ask yourself

How have you made a difference?
Who have you helped?
What was the result?

Example (illustrative)

“I started a weekly study group for younger students in my neighbourhood. Over one term, 15 students attended regularly, and I taught basic computer skills that helped them complete their school projects.”

4. Future Vision & Program Fit

Paragraph 5

Finish by looking ahead. Explain what you will do with your education and why this particular opportunity is the right one.

What to include

- **Short- and long-term goals:** State what you plan to do immediately after your studies, and where you see yourself in 5–10 years. Be realistic and specific.
- **Why this specific opportunity:** Name particular professors, courses, or values of the scholarship provider that match your mission. Generic praise suggests you could send the same statement anywhere, so do your research.
- **Benefit to society:** Explain how others will gain from the provider’s investment in you.

Key question to answer: Why is this scholarship the exact bridge you need to reach your goals, and how will society benefit from investing in you?

Ask yourself

How does this programme fit your journey?
What will you contribute to the world?

Example (illustrative)

"After graduating, I plan to work as a software developer for an education organisation. Within ten years, I want to lead a team that builds learning tools for students in remote areas."

Before You Submit

- Does the opening make the reader curious, and is your field and goal clear in the first paragraph?
- Is every claim supported by a specific example or detail?
- Have you checked that all facts, dates, and numbers are accurate?
- Is the statement within the word limit and does it answer the provider's question?
- Have you named something specific about this scholarship or programme?
- Is the writing in your own voice, in clear and natural English?
- Have you proofread for spelling and grammar, and asked a teacher or mentor to read it?

Common mistakes to avoid

- Repeating your CV instead of telling a story.
- Using clichés or exaggerated claims that you cannot support.
- Copying someone else's statement or using a template without changing it.
- Sending the same statement to every scholarship.

Your goals. Your story. Your future.